

Session 27: The Rulers Below

Key Takeaways

- Humans are meant to image or mirror God (Gen. 1:26-27).
- Humans image God by their unity and diversity as one humanity made of male and female (Gen. 1:26-27).
- God is dianthropic—he desires and designs to work through (Grk. *dia*) human beings (Grk. *anthropos*). Humans image God by ruling, or cultivating, creation as partners with God.
- God imparts a huge amount of dignity to humanity by appointing them to rule as his partners.

Humanity in Genesis 1 (Anthropology)

Within the framework of the six days of Genesis 1, the appointment of humanity as God's image is clearly the climactic act of God's work because it's saved for last. The key moment in Genesis 1:26-28 is designed as a literary symmetry.

Day 6: God Delegates Earthly Rulers

26 **And God said,**
"Let us **make human**
in our image,
according to our likeness;
and let them **rule**
over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over the cattle
and over all the land
and over every creeper that creeps on the land ."

27 **And God created human** in his image,
in the image of God he **created him**;
male and female he **created them** .

28 **And God blessed them,**
"**Be fruitful and multiply,**
and fill the land,
and **subdue** it;
and **rule**

over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over every living creature that creeps on the land."

Genesis 1-2:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2020).

Observations

The literary symmetries invite the reader to compare the corresponding sections. The "image of God" statements are immediately followed by sections that unpack the meaning and significance of the divine image.

1. "And Let Them Rule Over ..."

In Hebrew grammar and syntax, when you have a verb of command or invitation (called a "jussive") followed by a clause that also has a jussive ("and let them rule ..."), it is meant to be understood as a purpose statement: "Let us make human in our image ... in order that they may rule ..."

For this point, see Thomas Lambdin's book *Introduction to Biblical Hebrew (1971 edition)*, section 107c.

2. "Male and Female" = "In His Image"

Notice in Genesis 1:27 how the three-line poem has three key elements in each line.

Parallelism of Genesis 1:27

Line 1	God created	human	in his image
Line 2	He created	him	in the image of God
Line 3	He created	them	male and female

Parallelism of Genesis 1:27. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

This poetic parallelism makes clear that the divine image is constituted in some crucial way by the duality of gender. Somehow God is imaged in a special way through the unity of humanity as one species that consists of two distinct others. Humanity is one and more than one at the same time, and this offers an important image of God's divine identity.

3. The Preposition "In"

The preposition "in" (Heb. *be-/ב*) attached to "his image" means "in the place of" or "instead of" (called *beth pretii*, see *Gesenius' Hebrew Grammar*, sec. 102p). Therefore, this verse can be read as "God created human in the place of his image/as his image."

Reflection Question

What does it say about God that he creates humans in his image to rule with him?